

Avoiding Disaster

How a Project-Based Approach Could Have Saved BioWare's
Anthem

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1 Introduction

Project management is a key element of organizational success, particularly for corporations engaged in complex and risky ventures (Duggal 2014). It provides the necessary tools, knowledge and techniques to maneuver through the process of taking a vision and building it into reality. A few examples of those resources would be the *Guide to Project Management Body of Knowledge* (PMBOK Guide), *Agile and Waterfall methodologies* and the *PRINCE2 framework*. Where competent project management is used, it can derive order from the chaos of the complicated process of executing a project. Similarly, a capable project manager can effectively lead a team through a difficult project while ensuring that the project is delivered on time, within budget and to established quality standards. Moreover, they can identify risks and communicate when the project is headed towards failure. Although this is commonly knowledge in most industries and corporations, there are instances where project management is improperly applied, resulting in wasted time, resources and reputation.

The failure of the highly anticipated video game title *Anthem* is a prime example of how poor project management practices lead to a disappointing outcome. Anthem is an action role-playing game developed by *BioWare Studios* and Published by the industry titan *Electronic Arts (EA)* – one of the pioneers of the video game industry, commonly known for multiple billion-dollar titles such as Apex Legends, FIFA and SIMS. With 9.4 Million views as of date, the project caught the attention of almost every gamer and critic when its gameplay was revealed in 2017. However, when *Anthem* was officially released in 2019, the project absolutely failed to meet customer expectations, selling for a measly \$0.01 at certain stores after a year from launch, when it was a triple-A title meant to be sold at the price point of \$60 (YongYea 2022). The project can be deemed a failure – not just in terms of failure to reach its planned time, budget and quality, but also a failure in terms of stakeholder & customer satisfaction, quality of delivery and customer adoption (Duggal 2014). Synthesising multiple articles related to both Anthem and Project Management, this essay will explain how the project failed by considering two areas: Poor planning and scope management, and Lack of communication and collaboration. Moreover, it will describe how project management principles could have been used to solve each issue.

2 Poor Planning and Scope Management

The development of the Anthem started in 2012 (Schreier 2019). However, just days before EA's Press conference in 2017, the name of the title was changed from

‘*Beyond*’ to ‘*Anthem*’ to avoid copyright infringement. In ‘*How BioWare’s Anthem Went Wrong*’, James Schreier quotes one of the developers, stating that “such a major last-minute upheaval might seem strange to an outside observer, but on *Anthem*, it was common... To some who worked on the project, it wasn’t even clear what kind of game *Anthem* even was until that E3 demo in June of 2017”. This outright proves that Anthem was a victim of poor planning and unclear goals. A project should have pre-defined goals, resources and an end date (Dodd, 2023), which anthem *didn’t have* according to its developers.

One approach that would have tackled above issues is the use of a project charter – a document that outlines the purpose, scope, objectives and stakeholders of a project (PMI 2017, p. 76). The use of a project charter would have helped to establish a clear vision and direction for Anthem, preventing it from suffering the identity crisis that it went through for 5 years of development. Moreover, it would have ensured a better flow between the 5 process groups – Initiating, Planning, Executing, Monitoring and Controlling, and Closing – instead of having to juggle through each process and having to ‘start from scratch’ every time the project ran into an issue.

In addition to the project charter, establishing clear objectives and defining scope are also critical project management principles that could have helped prevent the failure of the Anthem. According to the PMBOK 6th Edition (PMI 2017) clear objectives are necessary to guide a team towards achieving project goals. If a set of clear objectives were established on what Anthem was *meant to be*, it would have cleared up the confusion for a lot of its developers. Furthermore, accurately defining the project scope (time, quality and resources) is necessary to ensure that the project team understands the boundaries of the project. Anthem did not have a clear project deadline as its launch kept getting delayed on multiple occasions. Resources were not properly allocated as the EA kept switching development teams between multiple projects (Schreier 2019). The ‘Quality’ of the project was also unclear, as evidenced by the developer quote above. If those factors were clearly defined at the beginning of the project, most issues highlighted above could have been avoided in the development of Anthem.

	Purpose	Place	Frequency	Stakeholders
Initial Meeting	Introduce the project, objectives, goals, deliverables.	Video conferencing, in-person, etc.	Once	All project stakeholders
Team Meetings	Project management team reviews the status of the project.	Video conferencing, in-person, etc.	Ongoing	The project management team, individual stakeholders
Check/Recap Meetings	Update stakeholders on status and facets.	Email, Slack, video, etc.	Ongoing	Stakeholders
Project Status Meetings	Updating leaders and stakeholders on project timelines, etc.	Gantt Charts, in-person meetings, etc.	Ongoing	Stakeholders
Feedback Review	Giving managers, executives, stakeholders a chance to review and feedback.	Video conferencing, in-person, etc.	Singular or ongoing	All project stakeholders

Figure 1: The process of developing a project charter. It shows the inputs, tools, techniques and outputs involved in developing a project charter. (PMI 2017, p. 75)

3 Lack of Communication and Collaboration

The development of Anthem involved multiple teams and stakeholders – designers, artists, programmers, sound-designers as well as marketing experts and investors. The lack of communication and collaboration among these teams was a major contributing factor to the game’s failure (Schreier 2019). Casey Hudson – the creative director, David Gaider – the lead writer, and many others who played a major role in development, left the studio in the middle of the project. This potentially interfered with the line of communication between teams – as meetings were postponed due to having to recruit new lead roles for teams. According to former developers, most team meetings resulted in disagreements, and ended without a clear verdict or a decision. Schreier quotes one of the departed members in his article, stating that “rather than someone stepping up and making a decision about how to proceed, the meeting would end with no real verdict, leaving everything in flux.” Another developer adds that “stuff would take a year or two to figure out because no one really wanted to make a call on it.” Moreover, in times that a software engineer had questions or wanted to report a technical issue, they had to go suffer long queue times to get support from the central EA team, which allocated less resources to supporting BioWare as it brings in less revenue compared to the other studios within the company (Schreier 2019).

Project management principles such as creating a project communication plan, holding regular meetings and establishing collaboration tools could have addressed these issues by ensuring a clear line of communication between the vast number of teams that were involved in the Anthem Project. A communication plan, which is a document that outlines how the project team will communicate with each other, can

ensure that communication is timely, relevant and effective (TRINITY 2020). With this document, the project team could have established clear communication channels and protocols, which would have helped in difficult situations such as an unexpected parting of a team member. While proper conflict management most likely could have reduced if not completely avoided such situations (Snyder 2018, p. 139), clearly established protocols would reduce its negative impact on cross-functional teams when it comes to unavoidable cases.

While it is also a problem related to resource allocation, the establishment of effective collaboration tools could have improved communication between the development and troubleshooting teams. The use of better project management software, cloud-based file sharing and communication platforms could have streamlined the lengthy process of reporting issues and receiving support. Additionally, more meetings could have been used to review the project plan, identify risks and make necessary adjustments to ensure all groups and their members were on the same page.

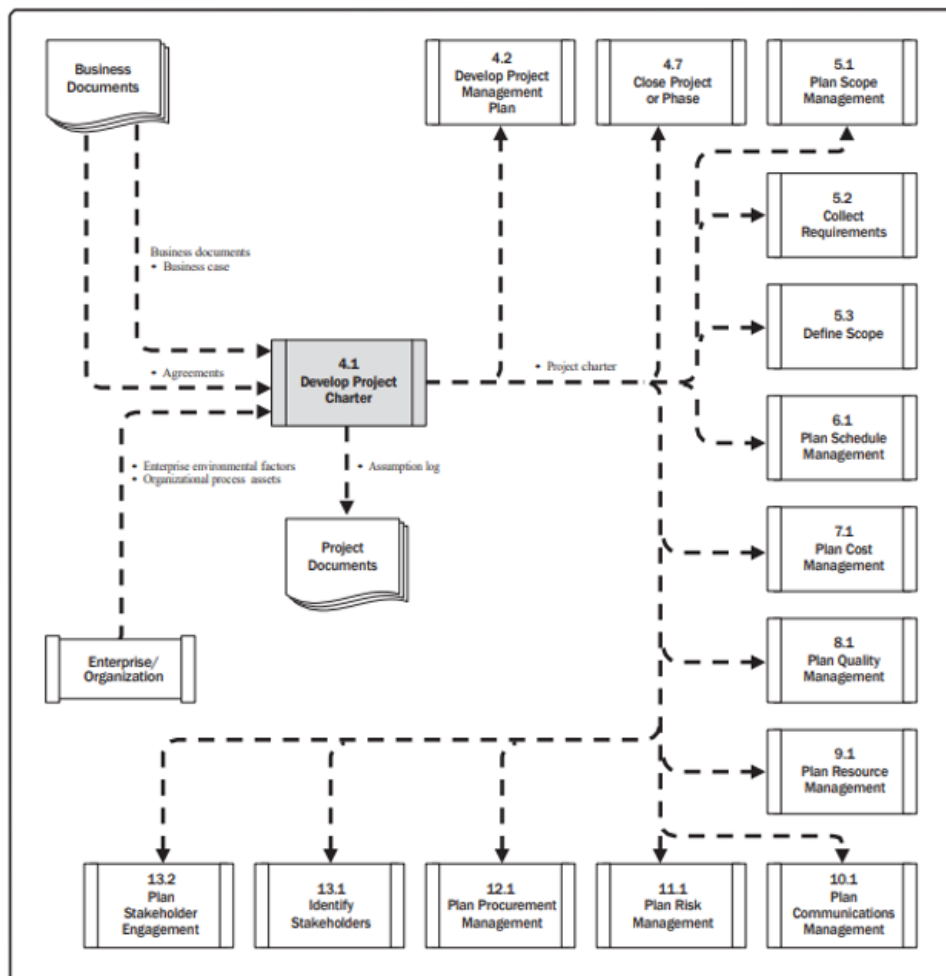


Figure 2: Example of a project communication plan. (TRINITY 2020)

4 Conclusion

In its life-cycle, Anthem had to undergo multiple reworks, launch delays and dozens of technical issues – which are key indicators of a poorly managed project according to the PMBOK Guide (PMI 2017, p. 10). Even though it was able to create anticipation within the community, it failed to reach customer and stakeholder expectations. While several projects were initiated to fix the product after its launch, they were fruitless as its customers gradually lost interest and moved on to other titles, ultimately causing BioWare to close the project in 2021 (Inside Gaming 2019).

Using the two areas – poor planning and scope management, and ineffective communication and collaboration, it is evident how the principles, tools and knowledge provide by project management could have been used to effectively solve and prevent the issues that kept disrupting its development process. The use of project charters, the establishment of clear objectives and scope could have prevented the lack of direction and the confusion regarding what the project's goal was. Meanwhile, the use of a project communication plan, regular meetings with established protocols and better collaboration tools could have streamlined the development process by making cooperation and decision making between each team easier. These processes, combined with a skilled project manager to implement them, could have saved EA millions of dollars, and shaved years off the 7-year long development process. Even if the project were to fail with the implication of such project management principles, it would have been easier to predict its movement towards failure and communicate that to the stakeholders and customers who were invested in the project.

5 Reference List

Note – references were done according to Harvard UofA style.

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